I'll Tell You at Sunrise

By Franky D. Gonzalez

Characters: *A well-to-do man; any race or age*
A homeless vagabond;, any race, age or gender.

Scene*: A subway platform bench.* ***Time:*** *Present.*

Directional Notes: Parentheses *indicate where the dialogue overlaps or is interrupted. A* ***Beat*** *is a change in the pacing of the conversation. A* ***Pause*** *is one second long. A* ***Silence*** *is between two and three seconds long.*

MAN: *(speaks in a weariness that has become emotionless)* Do you understand?

VAGABOND: *(has a calculating way of talking, as though choosing their words carefully)* I've dug ditches before. Filling one shouldn't be hard.

MAN: I mean, you have no objections?

VAGABOND: No. I don't -- just. . . I've always been taught that when you want to help someone. If I could help you some other way *(like convincing you this isn't a good idea)* --

MAN: You can help by doing what I asked you to do.

VAGABOND: But that ain't really helping you. Who you helping when you bury the dead? Isn't it more helpful to save a life?

MAN: So, you **do** have objections.

VAGABOND: You asked for help. I'm trying to help you.

MAN: I want you to do as I asked. If you can't do it, why did you say yes?

VAGABOND: You offer someone a few thousand dollars for an hour of work, you'd be a fool not to do it. But I'm gonna try to find a better way if I can.

MAN: But you'll do what I ask?

VAGABOND: I will. But I have a condition.

MAN: What?

VAGABOND: Talk with me. Until my train comes. That's all I ask. *(Silence)*

MAN: You want to know why.

VAGABOND: I do. Yes. You don't have to answer. But, I mean . . . what does it matter if you're

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buried or not? Once you're dead, you're dead.

MAN: I have my reasons.

VAGABOND: No doubt. It's just. . . I don't understand.

MAN: You're not getting paid to understand.

VAGABOND: No. I guess not. *(Silence)* Whatever is going on. . . whatever it is, you can get past it. But you won't get past it ignoring your problem and dying.

MAN: I know that. I'm aware.

VAGABOND: You don't know me, so you don't gotta say jack to me. But, you got a family don't you? You got friends? Anyone that you can talk about this with? You can't get past it until you can talk about it.

MAN: Maybe I don't want to get past it.

VAGABOND: Then you wouldn't have asked for help. Every problem has a solution

MAN: I already found *(my solution)* --

VAGABOND: Suicide isn't a solution.

MAN: It's ***always*** a solution.

INTRODUCTION

**According to the CDC, the United States reported nearly 50,000 deaths by suicide in 2022 and for 2023 rates continue to rise.*

So, what should you do if someone you know is in crisis or may be having thoughts of suicide? Don't avoid the subject. It's a myth that asking about suicide will give someone the idea to do so. And you don't have to be an expert. You just need to show genuine care and concern.

Many professionals suggest starting a conversation with something like this: "It sounds like you're feeling incredibly trapped, overwhelmed, sad, (pick the best adjective to describe what you are seeing). Sometimes when people feel like this, they think about suicide. Is that something you're thinking about?"

In this selection two strangers discuss the topic of suicide. . . I'll Tell You at Sunrise by Franky D. Gonzalez

VAGABOND: What could possibly be happening that this is the solution? *(Pause)* If this were a solution to the problems of life, we'd all be dead.

MAN: How long until your train gets here?

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VAGABOND: You're stuck with me for a few more minutes. Sorry.

MAN: I didn't mean *(to imply that you were annoying me)* --

VAGABOND: I know what you meant.

MAN: Either do the job, or don't, but I don't want any more questions. *(Silence)*

VAGABOND: No more questions. Gotcha. But I'm gonna keep talking. Till my train comes.

MAN: Why?

VAGABOND: Because I care about you.

MAN: You don't know me.

VAGABOND: But I relate.

MAN: Yeah? Really?

VAGABOND: Yes. *(Silence)* I -- I was going to once . . . awhile back.

MAN: Once what?

VAGABOND: End it. *(Silence, then with hesitation and an attempted restraint of emotion)* It was . . . buncha stupid stuff. Happening all at once. Whole thing felt hopeless. And I don't know why. I don't really remember it, but I stayed up something like two days straight when I decided that I was done. And I um . . . had this thing about falling leaves, right? I thought that it'd be kinda romantic . . . you know . . . to fall like a leaf to the ground. And the . . . the door up to my apartment's roof, right? The lock was broken. I thought it'd be really .... nice. Just floating down. I don't know what I was thinking back then. But I remember that when I finally decided I was going to kill myself, everything became so easy. You feel that, right? Like there's peace at last. . .

And it sounds so stupid, but I decided that I was going to wander the city. Like a leaf floating and spinning around in the wind. And when I had nothing left in me, I'd jump from my apartment building. The last gust of wind for the leaf that couldn't fly anymore. *(Pause)* So, I spent all my money and walked till my legs felt like they were gonna give up. I walked back to my apartment building, right? And next to my apartment building was this Little Italy Sub Shop. And I kid you not, just when I was walking past this sub place, this guy comes out and sees me. He says, "Hey, you look hungry. Eat." And he hands me this sub and walks off.

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Never see him again. And I'm not even thinking, right? I just keep going.

And I get to the last flight of steps and I'm on the roof, right? This was it -- the last thing I'd ever see. Being honest with you, everything up there looked beautiful. There is nothing like looking at the skyline the moment before you die. It's breathtaking. And I start walking to the edge of the roof and I realize, I'm carrying this 12-inch sub. So, I'm thinking, what the hell, right? I sit down, my back up against the AC unit and I watched the city. The lights like little stars. *(Pause)* I don't know how long I sat there, but when I stood up again, the sun was coming out. And I don't know what it was, maybe it was the sub or the skyline or maybe at the end of the day we just need to wander around for two days and spend all our money and realize that this whole thing . . . is beautiful. Life is beautiful and eventually it all works out. A sub and a skyline did that for me. Most times that's all it takes. *(Silence)*

MAN: Did everything work out?

VAGABOND: Well. . . I mean . . . I'm homeless now. *(beat; they laugh).*

MAN: You're pretty funny.

VAGABOND: Thank you

MAN: So, life doesn't get better, eh?

VAGABOND: It's hard to answer that question. I don't know what makes a better life.

MAN: You have no home. You have nothing that you can call yours.

VAGABOND: But possessions can't be what life is all about, can it? I mean we leave them behind when we die, right? What about walking around with the sun on your face? What about a kid laughing when they see a magic trick? What about skylines at dawn, or eating the best damn sub in the world? What about that first kiss with someone you love? What about looking into the eyes of a newborn? Or listening to your favorite song on the road? Or . . . or sitting in a train station trying to remind a friend that life might actually be worth living? *(Silence)* Talk to me. You can't want to give that all up. Life's like the seasons. Ice eventually melts and every season has its fruit you can eat. Nothing is so hopeless that *(killing yourself is the answer)*

MAN: *(loudly and then lowering)* Enough! Please. Just. . . *(Silence)*

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VAGABOND: I'm sorry. I didn't mean *(to overstep my boundaries)*

MAN: It's okay.

VAGABOND: Look, I'm not trying to be one of those bullshit self-help guides, because that stuff's fake. I just want to reach you, man. I want you to see another side to this. I'm not going to promise that things are going to get better. I'm not going to lie to you and say that it's gonna fix itself, but there's always a chance. You can't discount hope. Sure. There's a chance it might not get better. But we both know it almost always does. If not, at least it'll get tolerable. But I ain't gonna try to stop you. This is the one thing that you have absolute control over and it's not for me to take that away from you, but please. Please reconsider. *(Silence)*

MAN: Go over it with me again . . . what you're gonna do tomorrow. *(Silence)*

VAGABOND: *(sighs)* I'm gonna go to the place at sunrise with two subs from Little Italy Sub Shop and stand over the hole. I'm gonna call out to you. You're gonna respond, and I pull you out.

MAN: And if I don't respond?

VAGABOND: I'm going to pull you out of that hole at sunrise and we'll eat subs before I take you home.

MAN: But if I don't respond?

VAGABOND: Some things are easier to do than to say. I'm gonna do what you asked me if it comes to that. I promise.

MAN: Let me hear it. Please.

VAGABOND: If you don't respond, I take the shovel and I bury you.

MAN: Thank you.

VAGABOND: Don't thank me. *(sound of a train in the distance)* That's my train coming.

MAN: *(pulling out an envelope from his pocket)* Here take this. Half up front.

VAGABOND: No. Tomorrow. I'll take it tomorrow.

MAN: Okay. I'll see you tomorrow. Well . . . you'll see me tomorrow.

VAGABOND: We'll see each other tomorrow, man. I know we will. (*Sound of a train pulling in*

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and opening its doors. The Vagabond stands up and offers a hand to the Man. The Man shakes it) Until tomorrow. *(begins to exit)*

MAN: Wait! What's your name?

VAGABOND: *(turns back and chuckles)* I'll tell you at sunrise. *(he exits)*

(The man sits alone for a moment. Silence)

CONCLUSION

If you or someone you know needs support, please call, text, or chat with the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline or visit 988lifeline.org for 24/7 access to free and confidential services.

Playwright's Note: *The play's ending is left ambiguous purposefully. There is no "One Size Fits AII" solution to suicide prevention when you're trying to talk someone out of it.*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier

*****Source information for introduction statistic*
https://www.cdc.gov/suicide/suicide-data-statistics.html

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